

Anton Chekhov

1860 – 1904 | Russian physician, short-story writer, and playwright

Life & Background

- Russian short-story writer and playwright (1860–1904), born in the port town of Taganrog in southern Russia, grandson of a serf who had bought his own freedom.
- He grew up under the harsh discipline and beatings of his devout, bankrupt shopkeeper father — an experience that later gave rise to his famous line: "drop by drop, I squeezed the slave out of myself."
- After the family fled their creditors, the teenage Chekhov stayed behind alone in Taganrog, supporting himself by private tutoring and sending money home.
- He studied medicine at Moscow University and practiced it his whole life, saying: "Medicine is my lawful wife, and literature is my mistress."
- He often treated poor patients for free and volunteered to help villagers during famine and cholera outbreaks.
- To support his family, the young Chekhov published hundreds of comic short stories under a pen name before turning to serious art.
- In 1890 he made an arduous journey to the prison island of Sakhalin, conducting a census and documenting the wretched conditions of the convicts — a journey that deepened his social conscience.
- He battled tuberculosis for years and died in 1904 at only 44, in a German sanatorium; it is said he drank a glass of champagne before he died.

His Wife — Olga Knipper

- Olga Knipper (1868–1959) — leading actress of the Moscow Art Theatre
- Met in 1898, at rehearsals of *The Seagull*
- Married quietly in Moscow, 25 May 1901
- The great Chekhov heroine on stage — Arkadina (*The Seagull*), Masha (*Three Sisters*), Ranevskaya (*The Cherry Orchard*)
- A "long-distance marriage" — he in Yalta for his lungs, she on the Moscow stage
- Hundreds of passionate letters — their published correspondence a treasure of Russian literary history
- No surviving children — a miscarriage in 1902

- At his bedside at his death in Badenweiler, Germany, 1904
- Outlived him by 55 years — performing into old age, died 1959

Art & Importance

- One of the greatest masters of the short story in world literature; he transformed the modern short-story form.
- A pioneer of the "plotless" story: instead of eventful complication and resolution, he leans on ordinary moments of life, mood, and the inner transformation of his characters.
- The famous "Chekhov's gun" principle: every element placed in a scene must serve a purpose — if a gun hangs on the wall, it must go off.
- A neutral, non-judging narrator: he shows people's pain and weakness without preaching or prescribing a way out.
- A master of "subtext": the most important things happen in silences, in the unsaid, and between the lines — not in what the characters state outright.
- Many of his stories have "open endings"; he offers no clear answer and leaves the interpretation of meaning to the reader.
- In theatre, together with Moscow Art Theatre director Konstantin Stanislavski, he founded the modern realist, psychological style of acting.
- Deep empathy for ordinary people, combined with a wry and mercilessly honest eye for human self-deception and inertia.
- Alongside Leo Tolstoy and Fyodor Dostoevsky, he is regarded as one of the three giants of Russian literature: Tolstoy explored moral and historical questions, Dostoevsky examined philosophy and the depths of the soul, and Chekhov the quiet complexities of everyday life and modern psychology.
- His influence on writers such as James Joyce, Ernest Hemingway, Virginia Woolf, Katherine Mansfield, Raymond Carver, and Alice Munro has been deep and lasting.
- His four great plays — *The Seagull*, *Uncle Vanya*, *Three Sisters*, and *The Cherry Orchard* — are permanent pillars of the world theatre repertory, staged continuously around the globe.
- The word "Chekhovian" has become a critical adjective for works with a melancholy mood, apparent inaction, and sorrow hidden beneath everyday life.
- The Stanislavski system, developed on his plays, is the root of "Method acting" and modern performance worldwide — from New York's Actors Studio to film.
- Constance Garnett's early-twentieth-century translations introduced Chekhov to English-language readers and opened the way for his global influence.

- To this day the Moscow Art Theatre keeps the image of the seagull as its official emblem, on its curtain and logo.

Interesting Facts

- He wrote more than 600 short stories — from the brief comic sketches of his youth to the mature masterpieces of his final years.
- The narrative principle "Chekhov's gun" is named after him: every important detail introduced in a story should later serve a purpose.
- He believed a writer should "pose questions, not give answers"; the writer's task is to portray life truthfully, not to solve its problems.
- His stories still feel modern because they treat timeless human themes: loneliness, love, hope, disappointment, and the search for meaning.
- His plays remain among the most-performed in world theatre, and his stories among the most widely studied in world literature.
- He began writing under the pen name "Antosha Chekhonte" with short comic pieces for magazines, before writing under his real name.
- His famous remark on writing: "Brevity is the sister of talent"; and his celebrated advice to writers: "Don't tell me the moon is shining; show me the glint of light on broken glass."
- On his estate at Melikhovo he built three schools for peasant children, set up a clinic, and donated thousands of books to the library of his hometown, Taganrog.
- A crater on the planet Mercury is named "Chekhov" in his honour.

Famous Short Stories

- *The Lady with the Dog* (1899) — a Yalta affair; casual adultery turned real love; open, unresolved ending
- *Ward No. 6* (1892) — an asylum; doctor becomes inmate; sanity vs. madness; a bleak indictment of apathy
- *The Death of a Government Clerk* (1883) — a sneeze on a superior; absurd, fatal servility
- *The Student* (1894) — Chekhov's own favourite; Good Friday; the unbroken thread of past and present
- *Gooseberries* (1898) — false contentment; happiness built on blindness
- *The Man in the Case* (1898) — fear of life; suffocating conformity
- *The Darling* (1899) — a woman with no self but through others; admired by Tolstoy

- *Misery* (1886) — a cabman with no one to hear his grief; he tells his horse
- *Vanka* (1886) — an orphan boy's letter "to grandfather in the village" — with no address
- *The Bet* (1889) — a fifteen-year wager; the worth of a life against money

The Seagull & Uncle Vanya

- *The Seagull* (1896) first met with heavy failure in St. Petersburg, but its restaging at the Moscow Art Theatre was a great triumph — the seagull became that theatre's emblem.
- *The Seagull* is a story of shattered artistic ambitions and unfulfilled loves; the young writer and the aspiring actress are both victims of their own illusions.
- *Uncle Vanya* (1899) is a portrait of a wasted life: Vanya and Sonya have toiled for years to support a pretentious, hollow professor.
- The ending of *Uncle Vanya* is not redemption but sorrowful resignation; with the famous line "We shall rest," Sonya returns to the endless labour of living.

The Cherry Orchard (1904)

- Chekhov's last and most complete play, written a few months before his death; a work on the border of comedy and tragedy.
- A bankrupt aristocratic family that cannot prevent the sale of its estate and beloved cherry orchard to pay off its debts.
- Lopakhin, the son of a serf who is now a wealthy merchant, buys the orchard and cuts down the trees to build villas — a symbol of the collapse of the old aristocratic order and the rise of a new class.
- The characters are all incapable of decision and action; as their fate is being decided, they drown in memory and illusion.
- Chekhov considered it a "comedy," but Stanislavski staged it as a tragedy — this tension reveals the work's deep duality.
- The sound of the trees being felled and a snapping string at the end is an elegy for the passing of time and a world that will not return.

The Story of an Unknown Man (1893)

- A psychological novella about a revolutionary who infiltrates the home of a government official by posing as a servant, in order to carry out a political mission.

- But instead of completing the mission, he gradually becomes emotionally involved with the very people he is observing, and his purpose and resolve fade.
- Themes: the conflict of political ideals with reality, identity and the loss of purpose, love and disappointment, and the complexity of human nature.
- It begins like a political thriller but turns into a psychological study, showing that Chekhov cared more for human feeling than for ideology.
- Evidence of his belief that people cannot be simply divided into "heroes" and "villains"; the deliberately ambiguous ending pushes the reader to think rather than to a ready conclusion.
- Key takeaway: Chekhov uses the story of a revolutionary spy not to tell a political tale, but to explore identity, human relationships, and the gap between ideals and real life.